DOES PLACE OF BIRTH MATTER?

Differences in Education, Knowledge and Well-being in an Uneven World

NOT EVERYONE CAN READ.
In the Central African Republic, only 38.5% of young people are literate..

Figure 1. Global Youth Literacy Map (ages 15–24)
Source: Author's own visualisation [1].

DIVERSITY OF OUR WORLD

In Europe and other developed regions, technological and economic progress is often taken for granted, creating the impression that similar opportunities are universally available. This raises the question of whether such experiences are shared globally, or whether place of birth continues to shape life chances.
This study examines global differences in education and basic knowledge, focusing on literacy, gender disparities, and educational quality. It also explores the association between education and self-reported happiness, without implying causality.
Educational inequalities are well documented: in 2023, approximately 272 million children and young people worldwide were out of formal education, including 78 million of primary school age, 64 million of lower secondary age, and 130 million of upper secondary age. Despite rising global literacy since 2000, critically low levels persist in some countries [3][4].
In many regions, concerns related to safety, clean water, and food security may influence priorities, with education receiving less immediate emphasis—an association illustrated through the figures presented.

Figure 6. Maslow's hierarchy of needs [7].

HIERARCHY OF NEEDS

According to Abraham Maslow's theory, human needs are organised hierarchically, with higher-level needs becoming salient only after basic needs have been satisfied [5]. This hierarchy ranges from physiological needs, such as food, water and safety, to more abstract needs, including self-actualisation [6]. When the fulfilment of basic needs is uncertain, attention is directed primarily towards securing these necessities, while longer-term goals, such as education, tend to become secondary.
Although empirical support for the theory is limited, it remains a widely used interpretative framework in psychology [6]. From this perspective, in regions affected by armed conflict, food insecurity or prolonged instability, survival-related needs may dominate, and demand for education is likely to be lower, which is reflected in literacy levels.
Hypothesis:
The hypothesis of this study is that countries with lower levels of education also exhibit lower levels of subjective well-being among their populations.
(This hypothesis does not assume a causal relationship between education and happiness.)

NOT ALL CHILDREN ATTEND SCHOOL.
In South Sudan, one example is that 62.5% of children are not enrolled in school.

LITERACY IS NOT UNIVERSAL

Marked differences in literacy levels across countries are already evident within the 15–24 age group (Figure 1). For example, several countries fall within a similarly low literacy range, including the Central African Republic (38.5%) and Niger (43.5%). By contrast, literacy rates in more developed countries—such as Portugal, Spain, Italy, or China—are close to universal. Nevertheless, literacy does not reach 100% in all developed countries, indicating that basic reading and writing deficits persist globally, albeit to a much smaller extent.

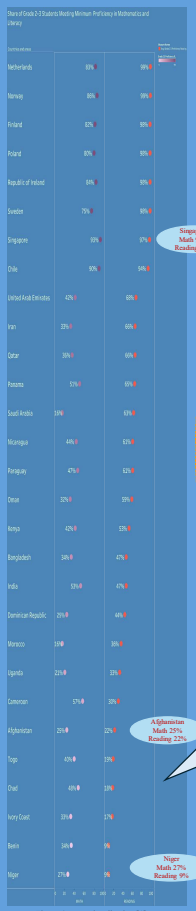

Figure 4. Own visualisation [1].

WOMEN AND MEN DO NOT LEARN IN EQUAL PROPORTIONS EVERYWHERE.
For example, in the Central African Republic, 29% of young women and 48% of young men are literate.

Figure 3. Own visualisation [1].

GENDER DIFFERENCES

Gender disparities further nuance the overall picture (Figure 3). In several less developed countries, female literacy rates are significantly lower than those of males, indicating gender differences in access to education and its social prioritisation. For example, in the Central African Republic, 29% of young women and 48% of young men aged 15–24 are literate, while in Niger literacy ranges from 36% to 51% in favour of males within the same age group.

NOT ALL CHILDREN ATTEND SCHOOL

Differences in literacy are also reflected in primary school enrolment rates (Figure 2). While primary education is nearly universal in developed countries, some countries show very high non-enrolment. In South Sudan, 62.5% of primary school–aged children are not enrolled, and in Equatorial Guinea the figure is 55.5%. In developed countries, non-enrolment occurs only to a limited extent, indicating that this issue is predominantly concentrated in developing regions.

Figure 2. Own visualisation [1].

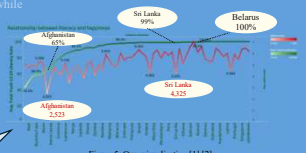

Figure 5. Own visualisation [1] [2].

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN LITERACY AND HAPPINESS

The relationship between literacy and the Happiness Index **(measured on a 0–10 scale)** shows a positive correlation, partially supporting the hypothesis (Figure 5). However, notable exceptions exist. In Sri Lanka, happiness remains relatively low despite high literacy, while in Afghanistan the Happiness Index is exceptionally low, even compared to countries with lower youth literacy rates. This indicates that subjective well-being is strongly shaped by factors beyond education, which are not examined in this study.

UNEQUAL QUALITY OF EDUCATION

School attendance alone does not guarantee the acquisition of basic skills (Figure 4). Differences in educational effectiveness are evident in the mathematical and reading competencies of students in grades 2–3. In some countries most students meet minimum proficiency standards, while in others many enrolled pupils do not. For example, in Singapore 93% of students meet the mathematics standard and 97% the reading standard, whereas in Niger only 27% meet the mathematics threshold and 9% the reading threshold, meaning that 73–91% of students fail to achieve minimum competencies.

HAPPINESS IS LINKED TO LEVELS OF EDUCATION,
although other factors can strongly influence it.

EDUCATIONAL QUALITY IS CRITICALLY LOW IN SOME COUNTRIES,
such as Niger, where only 27% of primary school students meet the mathematics threshold and just 9% meet the reading threshold.

DOES PLACE OF BIRTH MATTER?

The analysis demonstrates that global development is uneven and that technological and educational progress is not experienced equally across regions. While education and knowledge acquisition are taken for granted in some countries, basic literacy, access to schooling, and demand for learning remain major challenges elsewhere.
Differences in educational participation, quality, and gender equality show that place of birth continues to shape individual life trajectories. Education is therefore not only a means of acquiring knowledge, but a fundamental condition influencing long-term quality of life and social opportunities.
Analysis of the Happiness Index further refines this picture and provides partial support for the study's hypothesis. Overall, lower levels of education are associated with lower levels of subjective well-being, indicating a general co-movement between literacy and the Happiness Index. However, the data also reveal exceptions, showing that education alone cannot offset severe social and economic instability. In contexts of conflict, insecurity, or hardship, access to formal education is insufficient to ensure higher well-being.
Overall, the findings confirm that place of birth is not a neutral factor, and that reducing educational and social inequalities remains a complex, long-term challenge.
Therefore, place of birth determines your future, your opportunities, and even your happiness.

YES, WHERE YOU ARE BORN MATTERS.
Place of birth shapes your future, your opportunities, and even your happiness.

Data Sources and Methodology

This study uses a global education dataset from Kaggle, providing country-level data on access to education, literacy, and selected primary education indicators. The dataset was selected to support cross-country comparisons in education and basic knowledge and is directly relevant to the study's focus on educational inequalities.

The analysis is cross-sectional, as the data contain no time dimension, and no causal relationships are assumed. Missing and zero values were handled during the analysis on a case-by-case basis. The findings were compared with the World Happiness dataset available on Kaggle to explore potential associations between education and subjective well-being.
Data processing and visualisation were carried out using Tableau.

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